Introduction

The Lost Worlds of India

What does it mean for a world to vanish? As a kid, when I first came across the term ‘lost cities’, I was mesmerized. A whole city lost? *Lost?* How can that happen?

We live with the illusion that our physical and cultural worlds have a certain solidity and stability, that despite inevitable change, they will endure long after us, bearing our legacy and progeny. We maintain this illusion even when we’re aware of the many lost worlds that archaeologists have dug out—astonishing places like Machu Picchu, Angkor Wat, Memphis, Mohenjo-Daro and Persepolis. Since such lost worlds first captivated my imagination as a boy, I’ve visited dozens of them but I’ve lost none of my fascination for them.

The idea of writing this book was born on the road around 2004. During the preceding fifteen years, since 1989, while I studied and worked in the United States and Europe, I visited India only on short trips to see family. But smitten by wanderlust and bored with my profession (which only paid well), I often took time off from work to backpack solo in countries across Latin America, North Africa and Asia. I began to feel, as historian Miriam Beard wrote, that ‘travel is more than the seeing of sights; it is a change that goes on, deep and permanent, in the ideas of living’.

As I changed over those fifteen years, so did India, and I longed to discover it afresh. Happily, so did my life partner whom I’d recently met. In 2004, she and I took a two-year break from our jobs to travel in India. We visited 110 destinations in twenty states: natural and historic sites, mountains and coasts, lost cities and bustling metros. Eager for experiences, we stayed in humble hotels and travelled by foot, bus, train, boat, car, scooter, bike, rickshaw, camel and more. I also began to keep a photo journal on *Shunya.net*.